
Ernest Chausson

1855–1899, FRENCH

Born into an affluent Parisian bourgeois family, Chausson qualified as a lawyer and toyed with literature and the visual arts before deciding to devote himself to music. In 1879, he entered the Paris Conservatoire, where he was taught by Massenet and came under the influence of Franck. In 1883, he married Jeanne Escudier, with whom he enjoyed a tranquil domestic life, raising five children. Secretary of the Société Nationale de Musique from 1886, he hosted a salon frequented by the Parisian cultural elite, including the composers Fauré and Debussy and the Impressionist painter Monet. His own compositions comprised numerous songs and chamber pieces, as well as the opera *Le Roi Arthus* and a number of ambitious orchestral works. By the 1890s, he had developed a distinctive personal style, and he was in the full flow of mature creativity when he was killed in a cycling accident, aged 44.

KEY WORKS: *Viviane* (symphonic poem), Op. 5, 1882; *Symphony in B-flat major*, Op. 20, 1890; *Poème* (violin and orchestra), Op. 25, 1896; *Chanson perpétuelle* (soprano and orchestra), Op. 37, 1898